

BRIEFING NOTE

Uganda Coffee Farmer Profiling: What the Data Tells Us

Prepared for: X Country Director | 2,374 Farmers Surveyed | 4 Districts | May 2025

Summary of Key Findings

We have completed a profiling survey of **2,374 coffee** farmers across Kayunga, Luwero, Mukono, and Nakaseke. Below are the three findings that matter most for how X plans the next 12 months.

- **Production is falling in Kayunga**, our biggest district. Farmers there produced 148 tonnes less in 2023 than in 2022. We need to understand why.
- **Labour compliance is mostly clean, but two districts need attention.** 84 farms in Luwero and Nakaseke have workers who do not know their rights. This will become a problem if we pursue buyer certifications.
- **Almost none of our farmers are in a cooperative (5.1%)**, and those who are actually produce less than non-members. This points to an opportunity we are not yet capturing.

Finding 1: Production is Falling in Our Biggest District

Kayunga is the heart of this supply chain. It has **1,198 farmers**, more than all other districts combined. The data shows that total FAQ coffee production in Kayunga dropped from **1,342 tonnes in 2022 to 1,194 tonnes in 2023**. That is a fall of 148 tonnes, or just over 11%.

The table below shows production figures across all four districts. A note on reading it: the large percentage changes in Luwero and Nakaseke look dramatic, but they are not reliable comparisons. In Luwero, 274 more farmers submitted data in 2023 than in 2022, so the total went up partly because more people are in the count. In Nakaseke, only 32 of 262 farmers had 2022 records at all, which makes any percentage meaningless.

District	Farmers	2022 Total (kg)	Reporting 2022	2023 Total (kg)	Change (kg)	Change (%)
Kayunga	1,198	1,342,495	1,188	1,194,091	-148,404	-11.1%
Luwero	899	781,000	625	1,046,452	+265,452	+34.0%
Mukono	15	8,800	9	8,960	+160	+1.8%
Nakaseke	262	4,800	32	227,317	+222,517	!4,636%

Kayunga is the only place where we can make a fair comparison, and there the trend is going in the wrong direction.

What this means for X

We do not yet know what caused the Kayunga decline. It could be a weather event, a pest problem, or farmers selling to a different buyer. Until we know, we cannot confidently plan how much coffee we will be able to buy next season. A short field assessment in Kayunga should be a priority before the next harvest.

Finding 2: Labour Compliance Gaps in Luwero and Nakaseke

The survey asked farmers about three labour practices: whether they use child workers, whether their workers know their rights, and whether workers follow a 48-hour weekly schedule.

The good news is that zero farms across all four districts report using child workers. That is a clean result.

However, 84 farms have workers who say they are not aware of their rights. A further 44 farms report workers not following the required schedule. Both issues are almost entirely limited to Luwero and Nakaseke, as the table below shows.

District	Total Farms	Child Workers	Unaware of Rights	Schedule Non-Compliance	% Unaware	% Non-Compliant
Kayunga	1,198	0	0	0	0.0%	0.0%
Luwero	899	0	51	22	5.7%	2.4%
Mukono	15	0	0	0	0.0%	0.0%
Nakaseke	262	0	33	22	12.6%	8.4%

In Nakaseke, nearly 1 in 8 farms has a rights awareness problem. Kayunga and Mukono are completely clean on all three measures.

What this means for X

If X wants to pursue certification from buyers who require ethical labour standards (such as Rainforest Alliance or UTZ), these farms in Luwero and Nakaseke would fail an audit today. The scale is manageable. These are 84 farms in specific districts, not a supply-chain-wide problem. A targeted training programme in these two districts before the next buyer conversation would close the gap.

Finding 3: Cooperatives Are Underperforming and Underused

Only 121 of our 2,374 farmers are members of a coffee cooperative. That is 5.1%. In most well-functioning agricultural supply chains, cooperative membership helps farmers get better prices, access training, and improve yields. That is not what we are seeing here.

The table below compares cooperative members against non-members across five metrics.

Metric	Coop Members (121)	Non-Members (2,251)	Difference
Average farm size	4.1 acres	2.4 acres	+72.8%
Average productive trees	1,029	1,032	Similar
Average trees per acre	397	991	-59.9%
Average FAQ production 2022	794 kg	1,167 kg	-31.9%
Average FAQ production 2023	850 kg	1,056 kg	-19.5%

Cooperative members have larger farms on average (4.1 acres versus 2.4 acres), which might suggest they should be producing more. But they are not. They grow fewer trees per acre (397 versus 991) and produce less coffee per farmer in both years. The bigger farms are not being used as productively.

What this means for X

There are two ways to read this. Either the existing cooperatives are not providing the kind of support that actually improves productivity, or cooperative members tend to be older, established farmers who farm less intensively. In either case, the 94.9% of farmers who belong to no cooperative represent a significant opportunity. If X can design an aggregation or cooperative model that delivers real value to farmers, there is a large base to work with.

A Note on Data Quality

These findings are based on real survey data, and we have been careful to flag where the numbers need to be treated with caution. The following limitations are worth keeping in mind:

- o Production comparisons outside Kayunga are unreliable. Too few farmers in Luwero and Nakaseke submitted 2022 data for the year-on-year changes to mean anything.
- o Some farm size figures look incorrect. In 318 cases, the number of productive trees recorded is higher than the total number of trees the farmer estimated having. That is not possible, and those records have been flagged for review.
- o The Arabica and Robusta variety fields use broad bands (for example, 0 to 25 percent) rather than exact figures, which limits how precisely we can analyse variety mix.
- o The labour compliance findings are based on how farmers answered survey questions. Some of the variation between districts may reflect how the question was asked by different field staff, rather than actual differences in practice. We recommend cross-checking with a small number of follow-up visits.

Recommended Next Steps

- o **Find out why Kayunga production dropped.** Send a small team to speak directly with farmers in Kayunga before the next harvest. The 11% decline is the most important number in this report and we need an explanation.
- o **Run a targeted training programme in Luwero and Nakaseke.** Focus on worker rights awareness. The affected farms are known and geographically concentrated, which makes this straightforward to execute. Doing this now avoids a certification problem later.
- o **Redesign the survey for next year.** Switch to exact percentages for variety data, make 2022 production mandatory for returning farmers, and add GPS-based farm boundary recording to fix the farm size gaps.

Analysis based on 2,374 farmer records from the X Uganda profiling dataset. For internal use only.